

Elena Sirotkina

Computational Political Behavior

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RESEARCH

I am a political scientist using generative AI and computational methods to study political behavior at scale. My work asks how political identity organizes the way people perceive and act, and how identity can be recovered from behavioral signals and embedded inside computer-vision models.

Fields: computational political behavior; political communication; American politics.

Methods: computer vision and images-as-data; eye-tracking and gaze modeling; audio-as-data; text-as-data; generative AI and large language models; experiments.

EMPLOYMENT

New York University, Center for Data Science 2025–present
Data Science Assistant Professor / Faculty Fellow

EDUCATION

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill 2019–2025
Ph.D., Political Science, 2025
M.A., Political Science, 2022

JOB MARKET PAPER

Reading Between the Eyes: A Framework for Recovering (Political) Identity from Eye-Tracking Weak Signal. Uses computer vision and gaze data to learn political identity from the weak behavioral signal of eye tracking.

PUBLICATIONS

Media Choice and Audience Perceptions: Evidence from Visual Framing of Immigration in News Stories. (with Olga Gasparyan). *PLOS ONE*, 2025, 20(9).

The 2026 Europe Report of the Lancet Countdown on Health and Climate Change: Narrowing Window for Decisive Health Action. (with H. K. Kriit et al.). *The Lancet Public Health*, 2026.

The 2024 Europe Report of the Lancet Countdown on Health and Climate Change: Towards a Climate Resilient Future. (with K. R. van Daalen et al.). *The Lancet Public Health*, 2024.

How Biased Media Generate Support for the Ruling Authorities: Causal Mediation Analysis of Evidence from Russia. *European Journal of Communication*, 2020, 36(2), 183–200.

When the Party's Over: Political Blame Attribution under an Electoral Authoritarian Regime. (with Margarita Zavadskaya). *Post-Soviet Affairs*, 2020, 36(1), 36–60.

A Top-down Movement with Grass-Roots Effects? Alexei Navalny's Electoral Campaign. (with Jan Dollbaum and Andrei Semenov). *Social Movement Studies*, 2018, 17(5), 618–625.

BOOK CHAPTERS

Active Urbanites in an Authoritarian Regime. (with Jan Dollbaum and Andrei Semenov). In R. Smyth, J. Morris, A. Semenov (eds.), *Urban Activism in Contemporary Russia*, Indiana University Press, 2023.

Varieties of Russian Activism: State-Society Contestation in Everyday Life. (with Katie Stewart et al.). Indiana University Press, 2023.

WORKING PAPERS

Unpacking the Eye of the Beholder: Social Location, Identity, and the Moving Target of Political Perspectives. Develops a classifier for measuring (political) identity-specific visual sentiment.

Vision and Division: How Partisan Identity Patterns Visual Processing of Political Imagery. (with Olga Gasparyan). Large-scale eye-tracking study of motivated visual processing across the partisan divide. *Under review*.

Visual Political Polarization: How Partisan Identity Shapes Vision and Vision Reshapes Political Commitments. Registered Report (N=608). *Under review*.

Sounds About Right: Exploring Audio Dramaturgy of Political Propaganda. Introduces the concept of audio dramaturgy as the recurring organization of auditory features in propaganda.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Human versus Computer Vision.

Political Face Value.

CONFERENCES & TALKS

APSA, Visions in Politics, PolMeth (2026); JAWS (2024); VWAR, APSA, PolMeth (2023); Columbia/Harriman Workshop (2022).

VISITING APPOINTMENTS

Data Science Lab, Hertie School (Berlin) — DAAD Visiting Scholar	2023–2024
Ronald F. Inglehart Lab for Comparative Social Research, HSE — Research Fellow	2014–2019
Laboratory for Regional Political Studies, HSE — Research Fellow	2012–2015

GRANTS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS (EXTERNAL)

Horizon Europe (HORIZON-HLTH-2021-ENVHLTH-02-03)	2023–present
Expenses Support Grant, Institute for Humane Studies (IHS)	2024
Oxford LLMs Travel Grant, University of Oxford	2024
DAAD Travel Grant, Germany	2024
DAAD Research Fellowship for Doctoral Candidates, Germany	2023–2024
Humane Studies Fellowship (IHS)	2023, 2024
Travel Grant, IHS (×2)	2023
IHS Junior Fellow, Institute for Humane Studies	2023
Intensive Language Course Award (German), DAAD	2023
Understanding Modern Russia and Ukraine Grant, ASEEES (<i>declined</i>)	2022
Gibbs Fellowship, Institute for Humane Studies	2022
Hertie School Faculty Activity Fund Award, Co-PI	2021–2022
Carnegie Corporation / Harriman Institute Research Grant	2021, 2022
Mercatus Center Research Grant, George Mason University	2021
Adam Smith Fellow, Mercatus Center at George Mason University	2021–2022
Russian Academic Excellence Project ‘5-100’, Lab Research Grant	2014–2019
Russian Foundation for Humanities (RFH), Group Research Grant	2016–2018
Center for Basic Research Program, HSE, Group Research Grant	2012–2014

GRANTS, AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS (INTERNAL)

James W. Prothro Student Paper Winner, UNC and SAPOR	2022
Harold J. Glass USAF Graduate Fellowship, UNC	2022–2023
Thomas M. Uhlman Fellowship, UNC Political Science	2019–2024
Dissertation Completion Top-Up, UNC Political Science	2019–2024
Summer Research Fellowship, UNC Political Science	2019–2024
Assistantship Award, UNC Political Science	2019–2024
Graduate Tuition Incentive Scholarship (GTIS), UNC	2023
Graduate Student Transportation Grant, UNC	2023
UNC Priority Candidate for DAAD Research Grant	2022
UNC Departmental Summer Research Support	2022, 2023
Summer Research Award, UNC CSEEEES	2020, 2021